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SETTING UP HOUSE IN JOSEPH LOSEY'S *THE SERVANT*

An upsetting experience

The figure of the house in Joseph Losey's The Servant (1963) plays as essential a role in the narrative as the eponymous servant himself. A classed and gendered labyrinthine structure, it both determines and participates in the fate of its quartet of inhabitants, whom it pits against one another in a succession of power games. The constant redefinition of zones of influence within the house results in a reversal of situations as the servant gradually gives up all pretence of propriety and takes over the master's property. His gradual empowerment takes various cinematic forms and ultimately leads to his master's entrapment in an increasingly dark and claustrophobic mausoleum-like house.

Keywords Losey; servant; house; decor; power game; claustrophobia

The opening scene of *The Servant* portrays Tony (James Fox), a young aristocrat, in his new London house as he interviews Hugo Barrett (Dirk Bogarde) before hiring him as his manservant to take care of everything around the house for him, unaware of the possible consequences of allowing a stranger to provide such a 'general looking after' (Pinter, 1991: 6).¹ The central couple of master and servant will soon be joined by Tony's fiancée Susan Stewart (Wendy Craig) as a visitor and, later, by Barrett's own fiancée Vera (Sarah Miles), who is introduced into the house as his sister and will stay as a maid.

The eponymous servant and the house itself – respectively the first and second 'characters' in order of appearance – significantly take precedence over their young master, who first appears on screen only after Barrett has partly explored the house. In the first shot bringing the two men together, Joseph Losey's emphasis on the visual in film direction is manifest in the ominous contrast between Barrett's dignified, upright deportment, enhanced by the door vertically framing his dark silhouette, and Tony's supine position at the bottom of the frame, as he is found reclining in a deckchair after, on his own admission, drinking 'too many beers at lunch' (ibid.: 4). This already suggests that the servant might well prove to be a predator who has chanced upon a perfect prey. Many shots will later display similar frame compositions foreshadowing the impending reversal of social order (Figure 1).

In the opening scene, as often in the narrative, the master is conspicuous by his absence, even when actually present. Tony, who fantasises about a gigantic project of building cities in Brazil, seems unable or unwilling to invest much of himself to make his new house a home. While the young man is idly drawing in the conservatory, Barrett – who masterminds the decoration – is soon shown acting the master with the



Figure 1. A dominant servant looks down on his prey in the shabby, empty house. The Servant © 1963 Springbok Films Ltd.

workers doing the house up, who resent his bossiness. Later Barrett, after meeting Vera on her arrival at the station, gives her a guided tour of the house while Tony is out having lunch with Susan. Similarly, Susan will launch her counter-offensive against Barrett, in an attempt to get the house and its owner back, at a moment when she knows her fiancé is out.

Exceeding the traditional denotative role of set as indicating time, place, mood (Affron and Jona Affron, 1995: 37) or class, the house is used in the film as a witness of and instrument in Barrett's seizure of power, as well as a stake and arena for the power game that develops between the four protagonists. Losey's 'Notes on the film' in the information folder accompanying the film on its release underline the interactive relationship between characters and set:

THE SERVANT is also about a house behind a familiar Georgian façade in a square dominated at one end by Christopher Wren and the other by Thomas Crapper, 'Sanitary Engineer by Appointment to His Majesty King George V'. It is about the changes that men wreak on this house, and about the claustrophobia and other malignant effects the house has on its inhabitants in our present era.

(Losey, 1963: 2)

Challenging propriety within a classed and gendered property

The immediate surroundings of the house are limited to Royal Avenue in winter, a desolate and foreboding square which the opening shot covers from Christopher Wren's Royal Hospital to the pretentious shop of Thomas Crapper, along a row of Georgian townhouses. The overtones of disease, death and defecation of this setting ominously imply that, from the very start, something is rotten in Tony's Elsinore – as Tony admits when he mentions a 'little bit of wet rot' in his new house (Pinter,

1991: 4).² Gilles Deleuze views this 'gravelly square' as but one example, in Losey's filmography, of what he terms 'originary worlds': 'strange, flat spaces' surrounding a 'derived milieu' which often takes the form of a 'Victorian house' (a Georgian one, here). Degeneration is embedded in the setting, as 'from heights to depths, . . . or from the outside to the inside, the originary world communicates with the derived milieu, both as predator which chooses its prey there and as parasite which hastens its degradation' (Deleuze, 1986: 138–39).

The shots presenting the house from the outside were shot on location just opposite Losey's own house on Royal Avenue, Chelsea. However, striking camera movement (including circular tracking shots) was only made possible by building a specific set at Shepperton studios for interior scenes. As Losey himself explained, '[t]hose houses are like that. But not quite. We had to distort the architecture a little to get it. . . . That was very carefully planned and it is a masterful achievement on the part of Richard MacDonald'³ (Ciment, 1985: 235–36). The complex set of the house was designed both to look slightly disorientating and to allow character movement from room to room. For instance, 'the lagoon-like Barrett was provided with numerous means of exit and entry; MacDonald provided a superfluity of doors including three to Tony's bedroom and a sardonically funny exit concealed within a bookcase' (Ede, 2010: 140–41), so that Tony lies unprotected and may be caught unawares at any moment.

A typical Georgian terraced townhouse, the four-storey house was 'conceived by Losey as a kind of upright conch shell, built around MacDonald's elaborate spiral staircase' (ibid.: 140), and its interior space is characterised by a hierarchic division into subspaces to be used by masters or servants – a feature of British society which Losey, as an American, exploited with the sharp insight of the outsider. The drawing-room and library on the ground floor make up the master's social space, where visitors are entertained, while the bedroom and bathroom on the first floor constitute his private space. The servants' quarters are similarly divided into a private space (the top-floor bedrooms and bathroom) and a working space (the basement kitchen): in this vertical spatial structure, the master is thus surrounded by his servants. Even though the latter have access to the whole house, their presence on the central floors is only appropriate when performing household tasks, and any private use of these rooms on their part would – and will – run counter to propriety and constitute a dereliction of duty. As it unfolds around the house, the intricate, paradoxical and gradually changing relationship between master and servant raises issues concerning property and propriety: although the house as property belongs to Tony, Barrett (encouraged by Tony's culpable *laissez-faire*) starts taking advantage of the opportunities for empowerment it offers, adopting increasingly inappropriate behaviours and revealing his initial prim and proper attitude to be only a façade.

However, the house in *The Servant* is not only the scene of class struggle but as a home, as 'a space of both social relations and privacy', it can also be construed as 'a deeply gendered and gendering, sexualized, and sexualizing space' (Johansson and Saarikangas, 2009: 12). The homosexual overtones of the film have been much commented upon, and the female figure of the 'housekeeper' is immediately used as a foil by Tony, who explains to Barrett in their first interview: 'I could have got a housekeeper of course, to look after the place and run the kitchen, but quite honestly the thought of some old woman running about the house telling me what to do . . . rather put me off' (Pinter, 1991: 6). Barrett himself introduces sexual ambivalence into the house: he selects conspicuously masculine

ornaments to decorate the house, while in the scene following the servant's return, the two men undeniably act like an old couple, with Barrett as a shrewish housewife constantly nagging Tony as the useless, unemployed husband.

Contrary to 'the historical idea of bourgeois and middle class home, where the creation and maintenance of home and homeliness . . . are women's tasks' (Johansson and Saarikangas, 2009: 13), Barrett replaces both a housekeeper and Susan herself as the homemaker. The two characters' constant vying for power over Tony and his house is enacted primarily on the ground of homemaking, as though they were trying to 'keep' the house as one keeps a mistress, through various ornaments, care and attention: as Ann Lecercle notes about Pinter's works, 'the "room" is something to be possessed not only as property but also as a woman' (1996: 29). On Susan's first encounter with her fiancé's manservant, she criticises the decoration and attempts to impose her own, announcing her intention to 'organize a proper spice shelf for the kitchen' (Pinter, 1991: 11). Susan's second visit is abruptly brought to an end as Barrett intrudes on a tender moment between the couple in the drawing-room. This inopportune intrusion – extremely well timed by Barrett, just after Tony has proposed to Susan, thus inviting her to stay indefinitely – obviously irritates Susan who cuts short Tony's attempt at excusing his servant's 'mistake' by barking, '[w]ell for God's sake, restrict him to quarters' (ibid.: 14). Unlike Tony, she already senses that Barrett exceeds his role as a servant.

The next skirmish centres on whether the bouquet she sent Tony, who is down with a cold, should be placed inside his bedroom or outside on the landing. Susan's recurring trademark as a homemaker is precisely this bouquet of long-stemmed, expensive flowers in a crystal vase, symbolising her attempts at occupying territory in the house. Thus, as she later comes specially to defy and humiliate Barrett, she first arranges one such large bouquet in the drawing-room, spreading the flowers so wide that they take up most of the space on screen. When Tony is left on his own in the neglected house after his servants' departure, similar flowers will be shown withered in the hall, a sign of Susan's ultimate defeat.

As they fight for every inch of the house, both Barrett and Susan use objects as symbols of power. Susan does not limit herself to flowers in her somewhat caricatural approach to feminine home decoration, though to little avail. Soon after his return to the house Barrett will get rid of the above-mentioned spice shelf. Pinter's dialogue itself takes up this struggle between servant and fiancée:

TONY . . . I like the changes you've been making in the house. You've been enjoying yourself, haven't you?

BARRETT *clears a little*.

BARRETT I have, sir . . . thank you very much, sir. Oh by the way, sir, I took the liberty of removing those er chintz frills of Miss Stewart's off the dressing table. Not very practical. (TONY *grunts*.) Haven't seen very much of Miss Stewart recently have we, sir?

TONY . . . Mmmm? No.

BARRETT My sister's arriving tomorrow sir, as you agreed.

(ibid.: 19)

Through these inconvenient 'chintz frills' and Barrett's perfidious remark on Susan's less frequent visits to the house, Tony's fiancée is successfully being ousted from the

house, which conveniently paves the way for Barrett's alleged sister Vera to make her entrance.

Shortly after Vera has seduced Tony, Susan's aggressive but somewhat desperate attempt at reconquering the house is materially based, in addition to the above-mentioned bouquet, on smothering the sofa in cushions (*ibid.*: 37–8). She attacks Barrett head-on by ordering him about and asking a series of pointed and degrading questions, particularly about home decoration. The servant answers these provocations cunningly, never departing from his subordinate role and obsequious tone while implicitly expressing criticism and defiance. Asked for his opinion about Susan's cushions, he only says, '[i]t's difficult to say what I think of them, Miss.' When Susan asks, '[d]o you think you go well with the colour scheme?', thus trying to humble him by reducing him to a sheer decorative element in questionable taste and suggesting he does not belong in the house, his simple answer ('I think the Master's satisfied') shows that he has understood what really matters, unlike Susan who has gradually become estranged from Tony by imposing herself on him. The very long sequence shot that concludes this scene ends in dramatic irony, with the young woman sitting down precisely in the swivel chair where Tony and Vera made love.

Redefining inner boundaries

The successive scenes in which Barrett and Susan try to get the upper hand of each other illustrate the social forms of territorial marking that shape the geography of the house. Indeed, the inner boundaries and thresholds defining which rooms are specifically out of bounds to servants – except as servants – are gradually challenged, relocated, blurred and eventually removed in a series of power games. Susan, whom Tony reproaches with 'yapping at Barrett all the time' (*ibid.*: 17), is endowed with an animal instinct enabling her to sense danger when Tony cannot, because he is too deeply immersed in the creature comforts which his social status allows him to enjoy without leaving his house. In the scene where Susan insists on her bouquet staying in the bedroom, the idea of territorial marking is ironically suggested by the solemn way in which Barrett, with a pout of disgust, sprays deodorant in the hall, as if to purify the air from Susan's presence.

The narrative moves on from one invasion by the servants to the next. This process of invading the master's own space is initiated when Tony finds a half-naked Vera using his private bathroom – where Barrett soon joins her for a sexy romp. The seduction scene between Vera and Tony in the kitchen at night later offers a revised version by Pinter and Losey of what a 'kitchen-sink drama' could be, in a stylised rather than realistic mode: here the basement kitchen, as part of the servants' quarters, plays its part as a set both visually, with its darkness and the chequered tiling in particular, and in the soundtrack with the dripping tap punctuating the tense silence. From then on, former boundaries in the house cease to be effective, with Tony and Vera flirting and making love around the house. The ultimate stage in the first cycle of trespassing and transgression by the servants is the discovery scene, when Susan and Tony find Barrett and Vera having sex in Tony's bed. Interestingly, however, it is Susan who stresses his rights as the owner of the house, insisting that '[t]his is your house . . . They're in your room, in your bed' (*ibid.*: 41), an issue which

Barrett downplays by stating that ‘apart from the error of being in your room I’m perfectly within my rights’ (ibid.: 41).

After Barrett’s return to the house, the narrative is organised in a series of games played by Tony and/or Barrett. In the ball game scene, the reversal of situations is made explicit in the dialogues, with Tony finally running off to pour Barrett a glass of brandy, but also visually and spatially, with alternate high- and low-angle shots emphasising Barrett’s moving up and replacing Tony on the first-floor landing. The staircase is also central in the hide-and-seek game, which enhances Barrett’s ferociousness throughout his suspenseful, animal-like advance towards the bathroom where Tony, terrified, is hiding in his ‘little lair’ (ibid.: 53). The whole house, losing some of its civilised aspects, becomes a den as characters prey on or fall prey to one another.

In a more general strategic approach, Barrett and Vera, like experienced chess players, aim at controlling precisely the centre of the chessboard – i.e. the central floors of the house – in order to eventually dominate the whole space.

The impulse scours the milieu, knowing no satisfaction other than that of taking possession of that which seems to be closed to it, to belong by rights to another milieu, to a higher level. Hence perversion in Losey, which consists both in this propagation of degradation and in the election or choice of the ‘fragment’ which is most difficult to attain. *The Servant* illustrates this investment of the master and the house by the servant.

(Deleuze, 1986: 137)

As the narrative structure of the film follows the successive steps in the servants’ appropriation of the master’s private rooms, the space inside the house, which used to be shared out between the characters depending on their social status, is eventually shared in a new *modus vivendi*, and for Tony foreclosure of the other becomes virtually impossible: otherness penetrates the house in the guise of the servant, but also through his accomplice Vera and their friends in the final orgy, or even Barrett’s gifts – in the German sense of *Gift* (poison), in the case of the suspicious drink bought from ‘a little man in Jermyn Street’ (Pinter, 1991: 55).

The very structure of the house, though physically unchanged, takes on a radically different meaning. ‘Homemaking is an ongoing spatial and temporal process. . . . Homes are constantly made and remade and their meanings re-negotiated’ (Johansson and Saarikangas, 2009: 19), and indeed, the house itself changes to a notable extent in the film. In fact, as under Barrett’s ‘watchful eye, the house takes shapes and becomes almost a physical extension of the servant himself’ (Palmer and Riley, 1993: 47), it bears the servant’s imprint instead of Tony’s. If ‘[h]ouses and dwellings are transformed into homes through the acts of habitation and home-making, as well as through the sense of belonging created in these processes’ (Johansson and Saarikangas, 2009: 10), then it has, strictly speaking, become Barrett’s house.

The house trap: a victory of the camera (obscura)

In this respect, Tony’s house does not correspond to the notion of home as a place characterised by its steady nature which enables one to become oneself, the

foundation stone in one's quest for selfhood (Serfaty-Garzon, 2003: 72). Even a unified cinematic set 'cannot be said to be single because it shifts with each movement of the camera, each distance and angle, each framing' (Affron and Jona Affron, 1995: 33); but here the set of the house itself evolves throughout the film, and Losey uses Richard MacDonald's art direction and Douglas Slocombe's photography to convey its alterations and growing claustrophobia. 'The lighting cameraman, Douglas Slocombe, explains that the interior of the house passed through four phases: empty and cold; painted and beautiful; rotting; partially redecorated with a "gaudy, meretricious look"' (Caute, 1994: 10), the last one in keeping with Barrett's own aesthetic choices. An ascending phase is thus followed by decline, as 'the interior in *The Servant* is dressed and undressed, adorned and sullied: in a word, decorated and desecrated' (Lecerclé, 1996: 29). The continuous degradation of the house in the second part of the film, along with its master's decadence from a nonchalant young man into an apathetic, dazed, puffy-eyed wretch, underlies the narrative structure of the film. Filth and untidiness pervade the house after Barrett's departure and, to some extent, after his return. After being 'given a makeover by the new servant', the house 'does not stabilise there but degenerates back into disorder' (Barnwell, 2004: 42), and when Tony orders Barrett to clean up some 'tea dregs on the carpet', adding '[t]ake your pigsty somewhere else', Barrett cleverly reverses the ownership issue by answering '[i]t's not my pigsty, it's yours' (Pinter, 1991: 49–50).

Although some scenes in the film are set elsewhere, the house 'is a repeated figure to which the action is obliged to return', and in the case of such a circumscribed set, '[d]ecor becomes the narrative's organizing image, a figure that stands for the narrative itself' (Affron and Jona Affron, 1995: 158–59). Indeed, the 'centripetal pull of the house' (Palmer and Riley, 1993: 50) pervades the film: characters are shown approaching the house, but seldom leaving it. Only Susan – the one character who doesn't live in the house and therefore is not strictly speaking a member of the household – walks away on several occasions. Despite her repeated efforts to get a footing in the house, she remains an outsider and is eventually evicted by Barrett, the man on the spot. Another notable exception to this homecoming rule is Barrett and Vera's alleged departure for Manchester, which is actually a sham exit as Vera is soon sent back to seduce Tony. Having a lover at home increasingly turns Tony into a home-lover, and his nostalgia for his house, which will cause the discovery, is obvious during his second stay at Lord and Lady Mountset's country house: as Susan suggests they go to her room to enjoy the view, he answers '[t]he best view . . . is from our room . . . at the house' (Pinter, 1991: 39). Later, Tony's desperate pilgrimage to Vera's now empty room emphasises the fatal attraction of this room in particular – 'an absolute blank trap' in Losey's own words (Ciment, 1985: 235) – as the closed skylight window makes any escape impossible.

As Barrett gains power and Tony wanes, both characters increasingly live 'in camera', with the house eventually closing in on Tony. Even telephone, his last connection to the outside world, becomes ineffective as a potential lifeline, or a thread provided by an Ariadne-like Susan to rescue him from this labyrinthine house run by Barrett as a falsely submissive Minotaur: Tony gradually stops answering the phone and picking up his mail, which is left lying unopened in the hall. In the seduction scene, although the phone rings insistently in the foreground of some shots, Tony does not answer Susan's expected call, which brings a victorious smile to Vera's

face. After Barrett's return, the outside world is more and more consistently shut out thanks to dark, heavy curtains usually drawn shut, as in the scene when Barrett is doing a jigsaw puzzle with Tony sitting prostrate next to him. Unable to even look out of the window, Tony internalises his own imprisonment: while children are heard playing outside, he stares blankly ahead and just says, 'I wouldn't mind going out for a walk. It must be quite nice out' (Pinter, 1991: 50). Even his fantasy horizon has shrivelled dramatically compared with his former dreams of Brazil. Tony's failure to lock out the Mephistophelian Barrett has turned the house into a claustrophobic tomb instead of a protective womb.

The locked or unlocked entrance door is a recurring motif throughout the film. The unlocked door in the opening scene was an invitation for Barrett to gently push it open and literally catch his unsuspecting master napping. After Barrett's intrusion into a love scene, Tony's rather lame answer to Susan's question '[c]ouldn't he live out?' is '[h]e's got to lock up!' (ibid.: 14). Later, Vera's mistake of omitting to bolt the door precisely leads to Tony finding out the truth about his servants. And at the very end, Barrett's act of bolting the door after Susan's final departure is emphasised by a close, high-angle shot. So, although inner boundaries shift, the outside limits of the house become increasingly watertight to Tony – and to the audience who is also gradually housebound, as 'Losey's and MacDonald's purpose was to take the audience inside the house and keep them there' (Caute, 1994: 10).

The lighting itself heightens the claustrophobia, as in the famous stylised scene when Tony (upstairs) and Barrett (downstairs) play a rather vicious ball game leading to a reversal in their positions: the staircase is turned into a shadow theatre, with the banister acting as prison bars and the characters silhouetted against the wall in a duplication of their conflict. On the whole, the film and the house become increasingly darker – both literally and figuratively – as low-key lighting prevails and light is subdued, with drawn curtains or niches painted black, for instance. Deliberately using black-and-white to enhance visual oppositions – James Fox's hair was dyed to stand in sharper contrast to Barrett's and Vera's jet-black hair and dark garments – allows Losey to make the film a life-size chess game, an image suggested by the 'Bishop's Move' removal van seen behind Barrett's dark figure in the opening scene, then by the chequered kitchen floor tiling bringing out Vera's bare feet in the seduction scene. Darkness eventually prevails throughout the house and on-screen, a sure sign that black won.

The progressive limitation of visual field and geographic space partakes of Losey's characteristic use of visual obstacles, frames and reversals. In his conception of cinema as an essentially visual language, sight is a form of might and voyeurism is a common feature: peering into a character's private space is but a form of encroachment, the first step towards trespassing or worse, as Tony himself unwittingly suggests.

SUSAN. Every time you open a door in this house that man's outside. He's a Peeping Tom.

TONY. He's a vampire too on his Sundays off.

(Pinter, 1991: 16)

Unlike Susan, Tony, successfully hoodwinked by Barrett and Vera's manoeuvres, lacks the keen sight necessary to ensure his survival. He is too indifferent to his

surroundings to notice that the numerous passageways in the house enable Barrett to lurk in the background, often framed in doors, apparently waiting on his master but secretly spying on him and biding his time. The consistent use of depth of field favours a sense of voyeurism in the house by introducing various visual obstacles, either intervening objects or frames within the frame, which act as blinkers to direct the spectator's eye. Losey's directing – especially his practice, in his own words, of 'breaking down reality and reconstructing it in terms of selected things that made it possible for audiences to see only what you wanted them to see' (Ciment, 1985: 167) – thus cleverly manipulates the spectator's scopic desire.

Ann Lecercle describes the 'preferred mode of scopic organization' characteristic of Pinter's best plays (which can be found in cinematic form in *The Servant*), 'a "mi-voir" – seeing by halves – crystallised, and indeed symbolised, in . . . a window-frame that occupies . . . the vanishing point' (Lecercle, 1996: 46). Seeing by halves in film can also be understood as a subtle form of split screen, as on Susan's visit to her bedridden fiancé. This scene is visually and spatially dramatised by an alternation of high- and low-angle shots presenting each contender in a distinct subspace within the same frame: Barrett is downstairs in the hall and Susan on the first-floor landing, but depending on the shot either of them can be in the foreground. While focusing the audience's attention on the fundamental imbalance between the characters, this editing tends to blur Barrett's and Susan's respective social positions.

Exaggerated, almost vertical angles repeatedly help convey the notion that the tipping point is close and an imminent inversion always possible. Within the house, the film displays various symbols of the upheaval of social values, from the swivel chair in which Tony and Vera have sex to the upside-down reflection of the final orgy in a glass ball held by Tony before his face, and, naturally, the staircase, which delineates 'a line of the steepest slope' (Deleuze, 1986: 136). Mirrors, as contact surfaces potentially allowing inversion between observer and observed, also play an essential role in suggesting potential reversal. In some shots of the tension-fraught confrontation following the discovery scene, for instance, Tony and Susan stand on either side of a circular, convex mirror, looking away from each other. The carefully composed and static frame, with Tony visible in both the real subspace (with his fiancée) and the reflected one (along with his servants), conveys the ambivalence of the master's situation, 'undermining Tony's position of mastery and separating him spatially from Susan – in effect, constructing a representational preview of the power shift that is to come'⁴ (Gardner, 2004: 145) (Figure 2).

Various aspects of Losey's directing technique thus create convergent narrative effects, relying on the house as both evolving and consistent set. In the gradual process of redefining zones of power, passageways in particular – such as hallways, doorways, stairs and landings – are both contact zones crystallising confrontation and pivotal strategic places to be fought for. Exploiting its central role as the backbone of the house, 'Losey constantly tortured the staircase into new perspectives, angles, shadows, vantage points, power points – a motionless object which was never at rest; the mute orchestrator of the human quartet . . . , the coiling snail linking the separate rooms, each of them a place of hierarchy, privilege or sexual subversion' (Caute, 1994: 10). Around the staircase, the house then becomes a theatre stage where Barrett, besides being the leading man and the stage director, also acts as the property master. He makes himself increasingly at home before taking over and literally bringing down his former master,

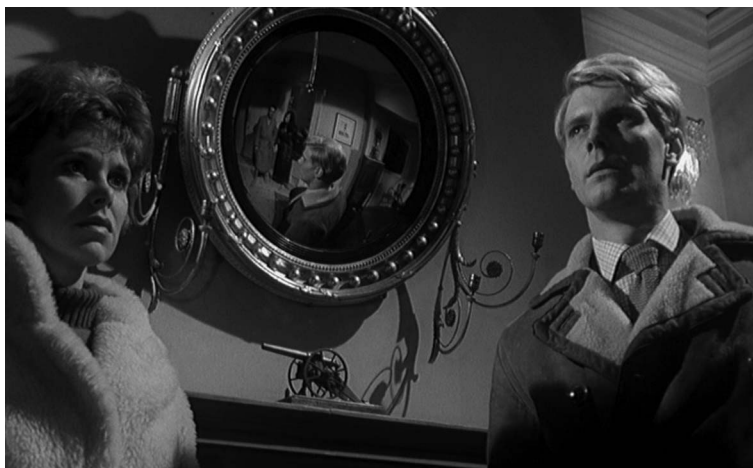


Figure 2. A convex mirror signifies Tony's awkward position. *The Servant* © 1963 Springbok Films Ltd.

while 'keeping' the house not as a housekeeper but for himself: Tony's failed attempt at setting up house finally turns into an upsetting of the original social order.

Notes

- 1 Dialogues quoted from the script are those used in Joseph Losey's film *The Servant* (UK, 1963, screenplay by Harold Pinter from the novel by Robin Maugham).
- 2 This Shakespearean reference is later made explicit in the hide-and-seek game, with Barrett's threatening 'I can smell a rat' (Pinter, 1991: 53).
- 3 Richard MacDonald, who was the art director for *The Servant* and several other films by Losey, though sometimes uncredited, was instrumental in helping the American director develop his concept of 'pre-designing'.
- 4 Another meaningful artefact of this drawing-room setting is the small cannon directed towards Susan, suggesting her imminent elimination.

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